

Centering Prayer¹

Begin with stillness, resting in your spirit and your natural breath. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause)* Lift the back of your head to straighten your neck and lower your chin a little. Reach the crown of your head toward the heavens and your tailbone toward the earth. You might experiment with standing during this meditation time as this can help focus a wandering mind. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, try asking God for a word, a phrase, or an image. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* We will use the simple term *word* to refer to these words, phrases, and images. Allow your word to float to the surface of your consciousness. It might be a Biblical word like *love*, *mercy*, or *Jesus*, or it might be a word of guidance like *let go* or *connect*. Some people identify a meaningful image. Stick to your word during the meditation time. When other thoughts intrude into your consciousness, gently return to your word. Breathe, and allow your mind to rest in stillness as you continue to recall the word. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

When you are comfortable with your word, try allowing it to float away from your mind. Dwell in the silence and rest in the stillness as your mind observes the breath. You might attend to the word for one breath and then allow your mind to repose silently for two breaths. Repeat the pattern. We will practice for one minute. Remember to consciously breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

During this last minute of meditation, we will let go of the word completely and allow our minds to rest in stillness as we observe the breath. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Take a fresh, deep breath as if you are stretching your insides. Gently open your eyes and re-engage with your environment.

¹ www.centeringprayer.com